

## GLOBAL METALS&amp; MINING

## Takeaways from expert call -aluminum smelting capacity: acceleration prompted by strong profit

We hosted an expert call to discuss the aluminum smelting capacity. The speaker is co-founder & director of research in an aluminum supply chain consulting company, mainly engaged in industry research and data analysis in the aluminum industry chain. The speaker highlighted what has changed in aluminum capacity outlook in ex-China, post his very recent visits to Indonesia.

The takeaway suggested strong industry profit has prompted accelerating capacity expansion by Chinese producers in ex-China, driven by projects in Indonesia and Central Asia. Overproduction in Chinese primary aluminium, beyond the 45mnt, would also persist in the current environment. The speaker estimated the output addition from China and Indonesia would reach more than 2.0mnt in 2026E. While total capacity addition from the Indonesia and Central Asia could reach nearly 6.0 mnt over 2026-28E, with bigger targets planned beyond.

In the near-term, the speaker commented strong orderbook momentum of exports, since April-May, in particular in unwrought aluminum and aluminium alloy products, aluminium sheet/strip and aluminium sections products. The change should lead to double digit growth in Chinese aluminum exports, and in turn translating to destocking of domestic social inventory, starting in June.

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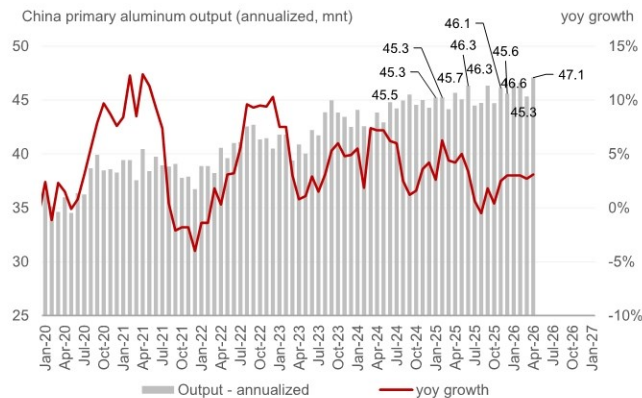
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**Exhibit 1: Monthly China aluminum output run rate reached 47.1mnt in April 2026, 1.8mnt higher than the average output of 45.3mnt in 2025A**



Source: NBS, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

**Exhibit 2: Based on speaker's recent trip to Indonesia, aluminum capacity and output addition could reach 2.150mnt and 1.975mnt over 2026-2027E, respectively, much higher than prior estimates done earlier 2026 for Indonesia**



Source: ALD, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The details of the discussion are included below.

### Indonesia - the fade of power supply bottleneck

The speaker commented on much eased power supply in Indonesia based on his recent trip, due to 1) allocating of suspended nickel smelting operation to more power for aluminium smelter usage in Tsingshan Industrial park, and 2) less than expected constraint on local power plant construction including smooth export of power generator units, in some cases 710MW supercritical thermal power units. While the control on mining activities has tightened including bauxite, the goal is more about better pricing, not removing support to the aluminum sector.

Based on his recent visits to local projects, the speaker estimated Indonesia aluminum capacity expansion to pickup in 2026E, with total capacity of 2.150mnt coming online in 2026E and 1.975mnt in 2027E, or 5.5% of the global market. The refreshed estimates are 1.6mnt higher than the forecast made in Mar-2026, of which 70% was driven by curtailment in local nickel operation with power being reallocated to smelter. The pace of new capacity ramp up will accelerate from 4Q26. Accordingly, the aluminium production growth is expected to reach 1.07mnt in 2026E and 1.825mnt in 2027E.

### Highlights of selected projects:

- Project A: the project started operation end of 2025 and current operating capacity reached 410kt. With the rest of supporting power generator starting operation in 4Q26E, the smelter is expected to reach full capacity of 500kt by end of 2026E.
- Project B: the project planned a total capacity of 1.8mnt in 3 phases, each with 600kt capacity. 400kt capacity in the first phase has started operation by May-2026 and the rest of 200kt capacity is expected to start operation by end of 3Q26E. 65kt capacity in the 2nd phase has started operation by May-2026 and the rest of capacity is expected to complete construction by 1Q27E. The phase 3 expansion is pending on construction of power capacity and delivery of generator units, but approval for power plant has been obtained.

- Project C: the project planned a total capacity of 800kt in 2 phases, each with 400kt. The project is expected to start operation end of 2026E.
- Project D: the project planned a total capacity of 1mnt in 2 phases, each with 500kt. The first phase of 500kt is expected to start operation in 2H27E and another 500kt in 2028E. The project already got approval for supported power plant.
- Project E: the project planned phase 1 capacity of 250kt and is expected to start operation in 2026-27E. However, the construction of smelters are still early stage by May-2026.
- Project F: the project has planned capacity of 600kt and located in Java Island. The local existing power is sufficient to support 300kt smelter capacity and is expected to start operation in 2027E. The rest of 300kt capacity would need construction of new power plant, which will pend on government approval.

The unit production cost of primary aluminum production in Indonesia is similar to China, or at Rmb15k-16k/t. The power tariff in Tsingshan industrial park is among the highest in Indonesia, at around Rmb0.46/KWh, higher than average tariff in China at Rmb0.41/KWh (VAT included).

#### **Other ex-China - big plans**

The speaker also observed accelerating effort in building aluminium capacity in Kazakhstan by Chinese producers, with total planned capacity reaching 5.4 mnt, of which of 1.8mnt capacity coming online in 2028E, equivalent to 2.4% of global market.

- Project G: the project, based in Kazakhstan, has total planned capacity of 2.4mnt in 3 phases, each with 800kt. The first phase of 800kt is expected to start operation in 2028E, with the site selection completed and piling commenced recently.
- Project H: the project, based in Kazakhstan, has total planned capacity of 3mnt in 3 phases, each with 1mnt. The first phase of 1mnt is estimated to start operation in 2028E.

#### **China - the recent environmental inspection, the 45mnt**

According to the speaker, the higher than expected YTD China primary aluminium production is mostly driven by unauthorized overproduction through illegal capacity and non-compliant operation of old capacity in capacity swap program, likely in the range of 1.0-1.2mnt, including: 1) unauthorized overproduction, 2) continued operation of old capacity that should be suspended under the capacity swap program, 3) intensification of current in potline in short-term period (an unsustainable practice that risks damaging electrolytic cells).

In the view of the speaker, the recent environmental inspection is routinely arranged, and is not targeted to control for aluminium industry. The speaker estimated China aluminum output to reach 45.5mnt in 2026E, 1mnt higher yoy.

According to the expert, primary aluminum production in China is estimated to reach 45.5mnt in 2026E, 1mnt higher than 2025A. The incremental output is mainly from three projects, 1) restart of idled capacity (0.35-0.4mnt) and ramping up of Zhalv phase 2 and Tianshan Aluminum.



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